

Fire or Water? Negating Religious arguments through elemental opposites in *Richard II*

“Some say the world will end in Fire, some say in ice” (Frost, lines 1-2). Robert Frost’s famous poem famously explores the end of the world as occurring by way of fire or by ice, the frozen form of water, the elemental opposite to fire. This poem unsatisfyingly does not assert either way that one or the other is more likely, forcing the reader to decide for themselves: what do you think? The topic of doomsday is often covered by religion, but Robert Frost leaves God on the sidelines in this poem. He was not the first one to ponder how to answer an often religious question without directly drawing in religion: Shakespeare does the same in his early history play, *Richard II*. This play follows the usurpation of King Richard II by Henry Bolingbroke, his cousin, and depicts the first actions in the sequence of events that will lead to England’s bloody and barbarous War of the Roses. In the play, King Richard is associated with fire and its derivative, the sun and the stars, whereas Bolingbroke is associated with water and its derivative, rain and storms. These elements are the perfect ones to juxtapose because they carry the same diametrical opposition in Elizabethan England that Robert Frost and our modern day conceptions: Tillyard, writer of the Elizabethan world picture, highlights the lines “Air hated earth and water hated fire” in Spenser’s¹ *Hymn of Love*.² Despite their opposition, Shakespeare uses them for the same purpose: to associate divine support with each of the characters. In a highly religious society, the right to rulership was often associated with religion. By ensuring both characters are divinely supported in *Richard II*, Shakespeare challenges the reader to think about the right to rulership and the circumstances that justify rebellion without religion.

Early on in the play, Richard is established as a ruler with divine ordinance and infallibility. In act II, Gaunt paints the titular character as “God’s substitute, His deputy anointed

¹ Spenser was one of Shakespeare’s contemporaries

² E. M. W. Tillyard, *The Elizabethan World Picture* (New Brunswick, N.J: Transaction Publishers, 2011), 20.

in His sight,” (Richard II, 2.1.39-40). This confers heavenly status to Richard as anointed by and handpicked by God to fulfill the role of King. Moreover, when Lady Gloucester pleads with Gaunt to avenge the death of his own brother, Lord Gloucester, Gaunt states that Richard’s actions, “... if wrongfully [done] / Let heaven revenge, for I may never lift / An angry arm against His minister” (1.2.41-43). The conditional “if” implies that it is not the role of humans to even weigh in on if the King’s actions are just or unjust, no matter how extreme, so taking action opposing the King would be even more heretical. It states that only heaven, not humans, may attempt to act against the king’s wishes. This echoes sentiments of the Elizabethan era that the King, as a deputy of the Lord, can do no wrong, and should not be opposed by human forces.³ Indeed, Irving Ribner expands on this idea in *The English History Play in the age of Shakespeare*, noting that Shakespeare agreed with this conception. Ribner concludes that “the concept of divine providence as the ruling force in a well-ordered universe” dominates Elizabethan culture and Shakespeare’s own worldview, and expands on this ideology as fueling the “doctrine of degree:” which spells out that “to aspire above one’s station is to violate the divinely ordained order of the universe, and such violation, particularly if it manifests itself in rebellion against God’s agent on earth, the king, must inevitably be punished by God.”⁴ In other words, divine intervention maintains order in the world, and the King is a deputy on earth of Heaven’s will. One who would oppose the King is opposing heaven, and this will lead to punishment. This explains why Gaunt is so hesitant to oppose the King, despite the fact that the King has murdered his sibling. These two ideas closely agree with each other, and Richard’s

³ Shakespeare was writing about medieval events, but was an Elizabethan man with Elizabethan worldviews.

⁴ Irving Ribner, *The English History Play in the Age of Shakespeare*, Reprinted [of the] revised ed. (Methuen) 1965, Routledge Library Editions - Shakespeare : History & Politics; in 6 Volumes 5 (London [u.a.]: Routledge, 2005), 103.

divine ordination in the play mirrors conceptions of divine providence and ordination dominating Elizabethan culture.

Richard's connection with the heaven's goes beyond this surface level, explicit characterization; God's deputy on earth occupies a metaphorical position in the heavens via comparisons to the central, life-giving star vital to the earth's daily functioning: the sun.⁵ Consider when Richard leaves England to raise an army and Bolingbroke begins to organize his rebellion: Richard describes the perils of a king who is away through an extended metaphor about the sun. He declares that Bolingbroke and other criminals can roam free and commit their sins "...when the searching eye of heaven is hid", but upon the King's return, Bolingbroke "shall see us rising in our throne, the east, ... / Not able to endure the sight of day" (3.2.37-44). This quote symbolically associates the sun, which rises in the east, with the throne of a king, and associates criminals and usurpers like Bolingbroke with the night. The King's presence, just like the sun, is vital for maintaining order. Shakespeare's conceptions of divine providence and order as kept by the divine king continue to concur with Elizabethan conceptions. Indeed, Tillyard writes that "The sun, the king, primogeniture hang together."⁶ In other words, the sun and the king are intertwined and as fundamental at keeping natural law as primogeniture, the law of succession which favors the first born. The King (and his notable customs, such as primogeniture) are not arbitrary keepers of order, they are divinely ordained and thus these customs come from heaven themselves- in the same way that the sun is divinely set to rise in the east each morning.

⁵ Fire is the base element underlying the stars. While Shakespeare may or may not have known that stars were actually composed of fire, he at a minimum recognized their association: In *Macbeth*, the titular character pleads "Stars hide your fires, let not light see my black and deep desires" (*Macbeth*, 1.4.51-52)

⁶ E. M. W. Tillyard, *The Elizabethan World Picture* (New Brunswick, N.J: Transaction Publishers, 2011), 103.

The imagery of the sun also implies longevity and invincibility due to the sun's constancy, magnificent power and radiant splendor. Surely then, no man is capable of snuffing out the sun. Kathryn Harris concurs in "Sun and Water Imagery in Richard II: It's dramatic function," by stating that "The sun is the source of order in the world of Richard's speech. The concept of divinely sanctioned kingship is invulnerable" to human forces.⁷ But this picture of the world and this picture of the way the world works is threatened by Bolingbroke's successful usurpation of Richard: both in the reality of the play and in the world of Richard the II.⁸ One must wonder, how can a mere mortal quench the sun?

One answer to this question focuses on the results of the rebellion. The play emphasizes the chaos, war, and terror that Bolingbroke's usurpation brings to England through the use of water imagery: the element that is opposite to fire, which underlies the sun which has so far represented Richard and Kinghood. When the Welsh captain chooses to abandon Richard because they believe he is either dead or soon to fall, Salisbury replies,

"I see thy glory like a shooting star
Fall to the base earth from the firmament.
Thy sun sets weeping in the lowly west,
Witnessing storms to come, woe, and unrest." (2.4.19-22)

This quote firstly reinforces the idea of the sun, kingship, and order. Salisbury connects the King's glory to a star (another cosmic image that is closely related to the sun) that is falling

⁷ Kathryn Montgomery Harris, "Sun and Water Imagery in Richard II: Its Dramatic Function," *Shakespeare Quarterly* 21, no. 2 (1970): 157–65, <https://doi.org/10.2307/2868826>.

⁸ I would be remiss to not mention that the current queen, Elizabeth and the rest of house Tudor relied on the "Tudor myth" that Richard's overthrowal was wrong and against God, and the institution of the Tudor's on the throne ended the chaos that ensued from this sinful usurpation : Ribner, *The English History Play in the Age of Shakespeare*, 104.

from the firmament of the heavens to the “base” or lesser than earth- he is losing his divine position as King. He follows with the imagery of the setting sun, which is commonly used to represent endings. As Richard, who has been represented by the sun, metaphorically sets, his reign comes to a close, and so does the order that characterizes the King’s reign. This quote is the direct opposite to Richard’s quote “rising in our throne, the east,” (3.2.43) concerning how the sun rises and brings order. This quote then brings in water and chaos imagery to represent Bolingbroke. Indeed, the line about the setting sun is directly followed by a lamentation that “woe, and unrest” with the coming storm, an image that also implies chaos. This represents Bolingbroke’s ascension as he usurps Richard. The water and storm imagery continues to accompany Bolingbroke’s chaotic and violent actions throughout the play. Bolingbroke warns that he will resort to force if Richard refuses to give him back the land he has seized ⁹ and “lay the summer’s dust with showers of blood / Rained from the wounds of slaughtered /Englishmen— /... It is such crimson tempest should bedrench” Richard’s land” (3.3.44-49). Water and rain becomes gruesomely conflated with blood, violence, and war in England caused by Bolingbroke- in other words, water becomes chaos, in stark contrast to the sun which is order.

But this answer still fails to address Bolingbroke’s capacity to overthrow the King. If God is omnipotent, why let his chosen King fall? This is a question Christianity and many religions have tried to grapple with for millenia: where does free will end and God’s power begin? If God is almighty, why let Eve eat the apple?

⁹ For the first part of the play, Bolingbroke denies that he intends to overthrow Richard, only that he wants his wrongfully seized land back.

Shakespeare answers this by slyly undercutting Richard's divine claim to the throne through fire imagery, while bolstering Bolingbroke's divine claim to the throne through water imagery. Bolingbroke's warning about the destruction he intends to bring extends in a long monologue, with one section that describes what he believes will happen when he and Richard meet:

“Methinks King Richard and myself should meet
With no less terror than the elements
Of fire and water when their thund’ring shock
At meeting tears the cloudy cheeks of heaven.
Be he the fire, I’ll be the yielding water;
The rage be his, whilst on the earth I rain My waters—” (3.3.56-61)

Interestingly, Bolingbroke shifts the chaos to the clash of the elements, as opposed to just describing water in a chaotic way as he previously did. While the chaos and war as the outcome of the clash is indisputable, and Bolingbroke's actions clearly fueled this clash, the water that represents Bolingbroke is framed in a positive light. Whereas Richard is described as fire and rage¹⁰ Bolingbroke describes himself as the “yielding” force of water. This symbolically shifts the blame to Richard, and it paints a picture of Bolingbroke putting out a fire that needed to be stopped, which implies a righteousness and virtue of his cause. He notes that this interaction “tears” heaven's cheeks. This crying imagery implies heaven's displeasure with the clash on earth, but he does not specifically condemn Bolingbroke. While one may argue that this is simply a tactic to justify his own actions, notice that there is another meaning to this quote:

¹⁰As aforementioned, while fire and the sun are not exactly equal, the sun and fire are tied together. But there are notable differences: fire loses connotations of order and constancy, and is instead representative of rage, which is a more chaotic emotion.

“tears” are water, and since they are on the clouds, they are falling to the earth as rain.

Shakespeare could have chosen to have heaven react angrily and send fiery lighting, to represent Richard, but Heaven sends melancholic rain, Bolingbroke’s element.

Moreover, consider that at the beginning of the text, Gaunt associates water and storms with divine intervention. In the same speech where Gaunt denies to Lady Gloucester that man may not act against the King, only Heaven may punish the divine ruler, he states: “Put we our quarrel to the will of heaven, Who, when they see the hours ripe on Earth, Will rain hot vengeance on offenders’ heads” (1.2.7-8). Gaunt conflates Heaven's vengeance with rain or a storm, a water based natural phenomena. It implies heaven could act against the King, and associates this with Bolingbroke’s element of water.

Shakespeare is simultaneously recognizing two contradictory ideas that exist about heaven and the right (or lack thereof) of mankind to rebel in this text by way of this fire/sun and water imagery. As Rimmasch points out in *Rebel Scum v. Rebel Savors*, two popular, contradictory texts set God against both the rebels and unjust Kings in Elizabethan England. The first text she cites is *An Homily Against Disobedience and Willful Rebellion*, written in 1571, which calls rebellion “an abominable sin against GOD and man” which will incur God’s wrath: “how dreadfully the wrath of GOD is kindled and inflamed against all rebels” This concurs with the previously demonstrated view that rebellion is against God. The Homily also notes that God doesn’t just punish the rebel, it punishes all of England through war, pestilence, and famine” which Shakespeare emphasizes through associated Bolingbroke and water and storm imagery with wars, such as when he states “showers of blood” or a “crimson tempest” which was “rained

from the blood of Englishmen” (3.3-44-49).¹¹ However, Rimmasch’s second source, *A Short Treatise of Politic Power*, written 1596, argues that there is nothing “more miserable, nor greater plague of God than where one ruleth, that is evil, unjust, and ungodly” Indeed, “evil governor[s] subvert[s] the laws and orders” and should be overthrown. This implies that a King himself is capable of disrupting the order of the law despite his divine vocation, and that this disruption is a plague sent by God, that is far worse than any other plague He could send.

Considering the paradoxical ideas of a divinely ordained King who is being opposed by God, we must revisit the passage that describes the meeting of fire and water as something that “tears the cloudy cheeks of heaven.” There is a pun in the word “tear:” it does not only imply crying but also implies a divide. The meeting of fire and water divides heaven because it is paradoxically supporting Bolingroke’s rebellion of a divine, invulnerable King. Tillyard summarizes it best: “The sun, the king, primogeniture hang together; the war of the planets [he cosmic heavens] is echoed by the war of the elements and by civil war on earth.”¹²

Indeed, this notion is supported by the fact that Richard disrupts his divine ordination early on in the text by breaking the most sacred order of them all: primogeniture. When Richard announces his intention to use Gaunt’s estates to finance his war with Ireland, York immediately cries out “How long shall I be patient?” (2.1.171) and proceeds to list all the many faults and wrongdoings of Richard, which include murder. But this is the inciting incident that tops them all, and it will eventually lead to Richard’s downfall. York warns him,

¹¹ Meghan Rimmasch, “Rebel Scum v. Rebel Saviors: Rebellion in Shakespeare’s Julius Caesar and Richard II,” *Journal of the Wooden O* 10 (August 1, 2010): 95.0.

¹² E. M. W. Tillyard, *The Elizabethan World Picture* (New Brunswick, N.J: Transaction Publishers, 2011), 19.

“Take Hereford’s rights away, and take from time
His charters and his customary rights;
Let not tomorrow then ensue today;
Be not thyself; for how art thou a king
But by fair sequence and succession” (2.1.201-208)?

Primogeniture allows Hereford (Bolingbroke, Gaunt’s first born son) to inherit Gaunt’s estates, and Primogeniture allows Richard, the only surviving son, to inherit the title of King. Richard violates his divine right by violating the underlying principle of primogeniture that underlies it. Primogeniture in Elizabethan culture is so sacred and vital to order that one might as well violate the cycle of day and night, which is governed by the rise and the fall of the sun. It is as if Richard has lost the divine right- another paradoxical but seemingly true statement, as it should be impossible to extinguish the sun and take away Kingship, yet Richard is still overthrown. Richard violated his divine ordinance, and so with weeping, rainy eyes, heaven will ensure that this is the last time Richard’s sun will rise.

But that doesn’t mean another sun will not rise in its place. At the end of the play as Richard symbolically gives up his crown, the sun/ fire and water imagery are inverted. Richard states “God save King Henry, unkinged Richard says, And send him many years of sunshine days” (4.1.230), invoking the imagery of sunshine on Bollingboke. He continues: “O, that I were a mockery king of snow / Standing before the sun of Bolingbroke, / To melt myself away in water drops” (4.1.271-273). Aside from explicitly calling Bollingroke the sun, he calls himself snow that is melting into water because of the sun. Whereas Bolingroke’s fire doused Richard’s

sun, Bolingbroke as the new sun-king now beats Richard's water. Bollingrooke obeys the will of heaven by being the rain, before assuming the role of the divinely ordained sun. In either case, Bollingrooke's actions as symbolized by both the sun and water are divinely ordained.

But this does not detract from the fact that Richard's is also divinely ordained. Even though at the end of this play Bollingrooke has seized the divine right, this does not stop Shakespeare from emphasizing the chaos and terror of the war of the roses through water imagery tied to Bolingrookes' rebellion. As war is a result of rebellion, The resulting war upholds the paradox: Bollingrooke is both a rebel whose actions are divinely condemned, but becomes a King whose claim to the throne is divinely supported.

Through this imagery of fire and water, sun and storms, Shakespeare the paradoxical notions that a King can be divinely ordained and shot down from heaven, and a usurper can be divinely supported but still condemned for his actions. This likely occurs in Richard II for many reasons. One reason may be that as noted earlier, the Tudor's leaned into the idea that Richard was wrongly usurped to justify their claim to the throne. Explicitly saying Bollingrooke's rebellion was divinely sanctioned or showing that Richard and divinely ordained Kings can oppose the will of heaven, so their word is not always supported by heaven, would be unlikely to make it past the censures.¹³ Another important reason to consider is the dramatic function. In a highly religious world, claiming divine support is the trump card when it comes to adding weight to a moral or political argument. In a text where Bolingbroke and Richard are both divinely supported as illustrated through this imagery, their claims cancel out. These actors must then be judged on their other merits and faults. Shakespeare also makes sure that both characters in

¹³ Ribner, *The English History Play in the Age of Shakespeare*, 104.

power lead to detrimental outcomes, so we are forced to consider for ourselves which state we would prefer: a world of disorder due to a rebel, or a land of disorder due to an unchallenged, unjust king. Would you take the constancy of the bad? Or risk a new world order that must be built through war and strife. Shakespeare has allowed us to ask ourselves and answer without religious influences: would I rather the world end in fire, or die in ice?

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